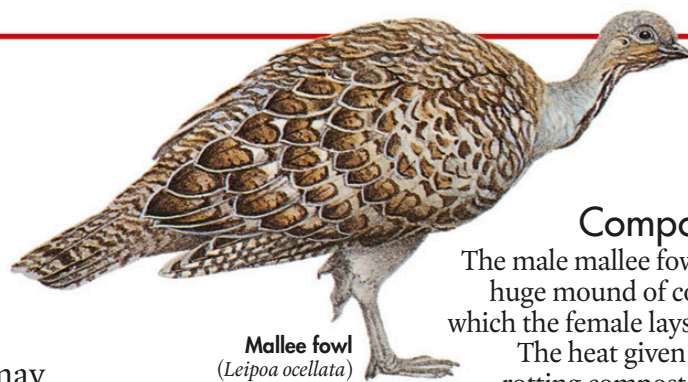


The Outback



THE DRY, DESERTLIKE PLAINS of the Australian outback cover more than two-thirds of the continent. Much of the region receives less than 10 in (250 mm) of rainfall a year. Although the rains may come at any time of the year, there are often long periods of drought, which are difficult to survive. Many of the animals avoid the heat of the day by staying in their burrows, since it is cooler and damper underground. Some small animals sleep underground through the hottest summer months. This is called aestivation. Many animals can also survive with little or no water. Their bodies are adapted to store water from their food and to lose very little water in their urine.



Mallee fowl
(*Leipoa ocellata*)
Length: up to
2 ft (60 cm)

Compost nest

The male mallee fowl builds a huge mound of compost in which the female lays her eggs. The heat given off by the rotting compost keeps the eggs warm. When the chicks hatch, they push their way up to the surface.



Short-beaked echidna
(*Tachyglossus aculeatus*)
Length: up to 17.8 in (45 cm)
Spines: up to 2 in (6 cm)

Frilled lizard
(*Chlamydosaurus kingii*)
Length including tail:
up to 3 ft (90 cm)



Frightening frill

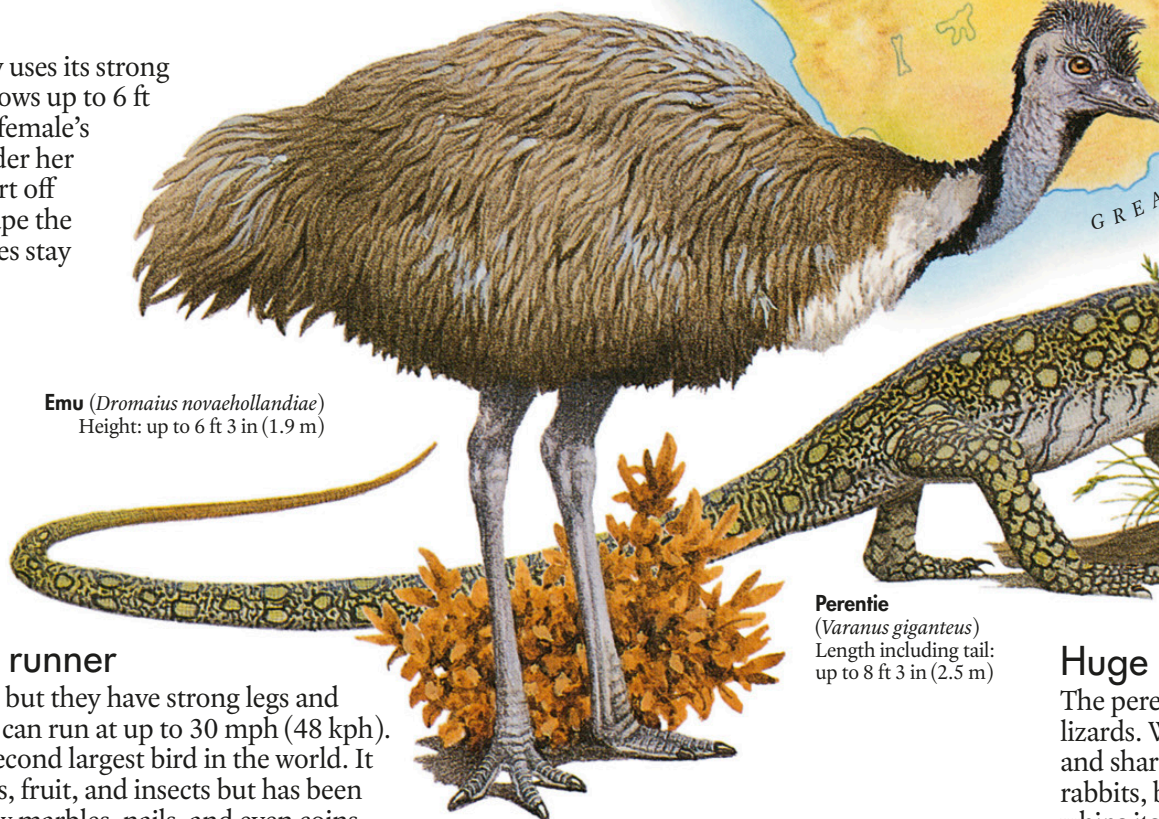
When a frilled lizard is attacked, it opens out the flap of skin around its neck to make it bigger and more dangerous-looking. It rises up and runs on its hind legs. Its bright mouth also helps it scare away enemies.



Greater bilby
(*Macrotis lagotis*)
Length including tail:
up to 33 in (84 cm)

Deep digger

The greater bilby uses its strong claws to dig burrows up to 6 ft (2 m) deep. The female's pouch opens under her tail; this keeps dirt off her baby. To escape the heat of day, bilbies stay in their burrows.



Emu (*Dromaius novaehollandiae*)
Height: up to 6 ft 3 in (1.9 m)

High-speed runner

Emus cannot fly, but they have strong legs and massive feet and can run at up to 30 mph (48 kph). The emu is the second largest bird in the world. It eats grass, berries, fruit, and insects but has been known to swallow marbles, nails, and even coins.

Spiny coat

The echidna's long, sharp spines help protect it from enemies. If it is attacked, it rolls itself into a ball or digs straight down into the soil. This hides its soft face and spineless underparts.



Uluru, in central Australia, is the world's largest freestanding rock.

Bottle trees survive in dry areas by storing water under their bark.

Perentie
(*Varanus giganteus*)
Length including tail:
up to 8 ft 3 in (2.5 m)

Huge lizard

The perentie is one of the world's largest lizards. With powerful jaws, huge claws, and sharp, curved teeth, it can catch snakes, rabbits, birds, and even small kangaroos. It whips its heavy tail sideways to defend itself.